

IMPROVING THE SOIL

To produce healthy crops, fruit and vegetable plants remove a lot of the nutrients from the soil. It's vital to replenish these by digging in an organic material such as compost or manure and applying fertilizer during growth.

COMPOST AND MANURE

Fill a compost bin with plant matter and kitchen waste, ensuring that you provide it with air, warmth, and moisture, and over the following months microorganisms will break down the waste into crumbly, sweet-smelling compost.

Making leaf mold is a slower process, taking up to a year. Pile decaying leaves into wire cages or punctured plastic bags containing a small amount of garden soil, and leave to rot down.

Farmyard and stable manures are packed with nutrients and are highly beneficial to the soil but need to rot for at least six months so that the ammonia doesn't "scorch" young plants.

Apply your compost or manure by either spreading a 4 in (10 cm) layer on the surface of the soil as a mulch, or by digging it into the soil the fall before planting.



Turn your kitchen waste into compost.



Mulch plants with nutrient-rich leaf mold.



Apply well-rotted farmyard manure.